

June 26, 1985

Volume One
Number Thirteen

The Largest Circulation Newspaper in Mecklenburg Co.



Raptor center aids injured birds

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the *Charlotte* LEADER



**Clark
Comes
Home**

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members of a committee formed to investigate options for the show are simply trying to get expansion help from the city. "I don't know if we need a new building or not; we may just need to build onto this building, or

Larry Henson of Esprit shows buyers new models to shine for the holidays.

pick up the second floor. The city just has to realize how much income this building brings into Charlotte.

"We don't want to compete with a \$50 million building with an atrium (like Atlanta's)," he continued.

And they couldn't afford to stay here, away from their shops, all week, either."

George Cutter, who has
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Center Helps Injured Birds

By ANNE KIMZEY
Leader Staff Writer

When a nest of Red-shouldered Hawks was destroyed in a logging operation near Wilmington, N.C., the Carolina Raptor Center was called to save the one surviving fledgling.

Once the orphaned bird was old enough to live on its own, it was released back into the wild.

That call was typical for the center, a non-profit organization devoted to the conservation of raptors, a collective term for birds of prey such as owls, hawks, eagles, and vultures.

Now in its fourth year of operation, the Carolina Raptor Center has become well-known in the Southeast for its efforts to rehabilitate injured raptors and to educate the public about environmental issues that threaten our wildlife.

Although birds of prey are protected under federal law, many still are shot, trapped, or poisoned. Others are hit by motor vehicles while hunting for animals attracted to roadside litter.

Injured birds brought into the center are treated with the hope that they can eventually be released. Permanently-disabled birds are used in education programs given to interested community groups or school classes.

The main threat to raptors is the destruction of the birds' natural habitats where they nest and hunt, said Mathias Engelmann, volunteer Rehabilitation Coordinator for the center.

"No matter how many birds you rehabilitate, if there's no place to release them, what's the use?" he shrugged.

The Carolina Raptor Center, which is currently located in its temporary facility at Latta Plantation Park, began under the direction of ornithologist, Dr. Richard D. Brown, an adjunct professor of biology at UNCC.

The basement of the UNCC biology building was the Raptor Center's home for three years until the Mecklenburg County Board of Commissioners donated more than 80 acres for the purpose of building an educational center with a bird of prey theme.

"What we're trying to do is
(Continued on page 7)

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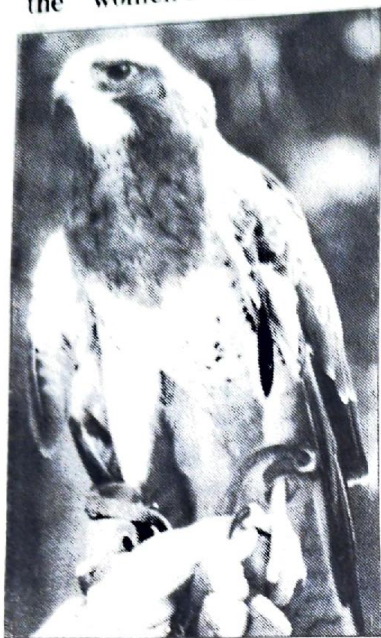
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Jane Powell & Company



market is suffering from lack of show consolidation. "The traffic at each show would be greater," he explained. "If the women's and men's

Civic Center complex, conventions and trade marts. "It's just a matter of someone looking at us and



Raptor

(From page 6)

set up our temporary headquarters, and from here develop the main facility," which will be located about 200 yards down the road, said Dr. Brown, executive director for the center.

"This will be a place that Charlotte will be really proud of," he said, adding that the center welcomes volunteers who would like to help care for the birds or assist in the many development projects now underway.

The Carolina raptor Center is now open to the public on weekends from noon to 5 p.m.

There visitors can see many of the permanently disabled hawks, owls, and eagles seated on their perches under the trees.

Volunteers are on hand to answer questions and tell about each bird.

"Helen," a rare Peregrine Falcon which was shot in the wing, and "George," a hot-tempered Bald Eagle with a dislocated elbow, are two of the permanent residents on display at the Raptor Center.

For more information on the Carolina Raptor Center, call 875-6521.

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